

LOCOMOTIF S. PRASANNARAJAN

The Obama Moment



The beginning as an ambition. The evolution as a phenomenon. And now occupying that rare space between history and destiny... We can only exclaim O-b-a-m-a, an invocation that has travelled far beyond the Democratic primaries in America.

Once in a while in the life of a nation, it happens: the arrival of a candidate who defies the gravity of conventional politics and concentrates the mind of a generation. Event Obama is such a moment. His historicity, mostly constructed by his own colour-coded back story, has been overemphasised—and almost mythified—by a star-struck liberal media. (Even some smart pundits from the Conservative commentariat can't resist his magic.) What is it that makes this freshman senator from Illinois an American sensation and a global brand? Barack Obama as a transformative force essays not only the power of the new in politics. By identifying with the politician who wants to end politics-as-usual, millions of Obamites, especially the affluent and the educated, have come to see themselves as some kind of velvet revolutionaries. Romancing Obama has become a rite of redemption, almost. It certainly makes the voter feel good. It gives him a sense—or maybe an illusion—of historical worthiness.

Is it that politics is so bad and bereft of ideas that the overwhelming simplicity of a slogan like “we are the change that we seek” can mesmerise a country like America? Well, the poetry of Obama's text is matched by the prosaic banality of the context. Obama has happened at a time when experience means nothing more than cynicism and entitlement. Obama, armed with an inspiring biography, has turned his political innocence—his declaration of freedom from Washington's triangulations—into a weapon of mass seduction. And that perhaps explains Brand Obama's appeal beyond America as well. Look at the leader at work today. In Washington, he does not have the intellectual or ideological sophistication to sustain his own achievement of a Saddam-less Iraq; in Moscow, he in his neo-Czarist delusion makes himself indispensable to a proud and stable Russia; in London, he is too scared to hold a general election; in New Delhi, even though he is not his own political master, he does not have the courage to stand by his convictions, nuclear or otherwise. Politics has become an assertion of the familiar. Obama has won the nomination by defeating the politics of professionally crafted expertise. Is he the change that we seek? The answer will depend on the extent to which American can change according to the dream of a man inspired—and inspiring.



SAURABH SINGH



Aiming At Centre Court

BANGALORE With the Congress biting the dust in the Karnataka polls, the high command seems to be making amends now. Former Maharashtra governor and ex-chief minister S.M. Krishna filed his nomination papers for the Rajya Sabha on June 16 as a Congress candidate. He was not even asked to contest the recent assembly polls.

Krishna's entry to the Upper House is seen as a step towards his induction into the Union Cabinet. It is also aimed at restoring the lost support from one

of the state's largest communities, the Lingayats, who are now at the helm of affairs in the state. Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa has also inducted six fellow Lingayats into his Cabinet.

Fulbright scholar Krishna, 76, is not new to Parliament. He has been a Lok Sabha member twice and was Union minister of state for industry and finance. He was last elected to Rajya Sabha in April 1996. For the tennis loving Krishna, it is time to move to the Centre court.

by Stephen David

Citizen Policing

MUMBAI Mumbai's seven lakh slum dwellers can continue to enjoy a relatively dispute-free existence. With Zopadpatti Police Panchayat (ZPP)—or slum self-governing body—celebrating its fourth anniversary in June, drunken brawls no longer end at the local police station and divorces do not come through merely by saying 'talaq' thrice. From domestic disputes and alcoholic husbands to fights, the city's

350 ZPPs address a variety of local issues before reporting them to the police. “We also inform the police about criminal cases relating to land grab, rape and suspicious activities,” says Malti Amre, ZPP's organiser in central and eastern Mumbai. Launched in 2004 by the then commissioner of Mumbai Police, A.N. Roy, the panchayats are an example of how grassroots citizen policing can resolve problems and spread awareness at the community level.

by Swati Mathur